

SWEET AND SOUR CHERRIES

Prunus avium and *P. cerasus*

Not only are sweet cherries a delicious treat picked and eaten fresh, but their trees are also renowned for their breathtaking displays of spring beauty. Although they are too sour to eat fresh, sour varieties are also worth growing—they are hardier than their sweet relatives, and the fruits are wonderful cooked and used in jams, desserts, and pies.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Select your cherry tree carefully—most are self-fertile, so if you only have space for one, ensure you invest in this type. If you are growing more than one tree, make sure that their seasons of flowering are the same—but bear in mind that there are a few varieties of sweet cherry that will not cross-pollinate each other, even if they both flower at the same time. Seek advice from a specialist at the time of purchase.

Cherry trees grow fast and can become large, so if you only have a small space choose a tree grown on a dwarfing rootstock. Trees may be bare-root or container-grown; if you are buying the latter, ensure that it has not become pot-bound.



Protect blossom from frost and rain.

Sweet cherries need a warm, sheltered site, and a well-drained, moist soil with a pH of around 6.5. Their blossoms will need protection against frost, so growing them against a south-facing wall is ideal, since they can then be easily covered over with fleece or netting, or plastic sheeting to protect the trees from rain. Sour cherries are less fussy, and although they need the same